Pooja, Then Quran, Followed by a Ram Temple Donation: An Older Syncretic Culture in UP and Its Questions

Reporting on another offshoot of the Ram Temple agitation in 2002, I discovered that my new mother-in-law from UP had herself been to kar-seva twice: before and immediately after the temple demolition. This was yet another example of how the political tumult of the 'outside' world plays out in complex, unexpected ways in our 'inside' family worlds. I spent most of 2002 covering the post-Godhra riots in Gujarat, which had started with the burning of fifty-nine kar-sevaks on their way back from Ayodhya. The election that followed was the making of Narendra Modi as a mass leader. Midway through that campaign, as I discussed the political rhetoric with a bureaucrat in Ahmedabad, she mused aloud about its psychological wellsprings. 'It is almost like they are taking revenge for Somnath, as if taking account for all those centuries of humiliation,' she muttered half-seriously.[7] Later that day, when I questioned my devout mother-in-law about what motivated her kar-seva, she insisted it was personal belief. She had grown up in Ayodhya's Kanak Bhawan,[8] within sight of the Babri Masjid. 'Hamaare Bhagwan hain (He is my God)' was her gentle but firm answer each time I attempted a wider discussion on her beliefs.

What about the underlying politics of the movement? What did she think it meant for Muslims? I could never draw her into a deeper dialogue on the questions I was used to discussing in my professional circles—the 'idea of India', 'secularism vs communalism', 'minority rights'. Her answer started and ended with faith. It confounded me because her gentle religiosity did not square with the aggression, machismo and anti-Muslim-ness I had seen in many of the movement's stormtroopers. Just when I was bracketing her in my mind as a one-dimensional Hindu nationalist, a new familial twist emerged.

My father-in-law, another devout Hindu, was equally supportive of the Ram Temple. The surprise was that his daily morning pooja at a Hindu altar was followed by another, more discreet ritual: the reading of the Quran in a closed room. The morning aarti and prasad would be followed by a religious recitation of the Islamic 'Bismillah-ir-